

Assessing the Costs of Incarceration to Families in Durham, North Carolina

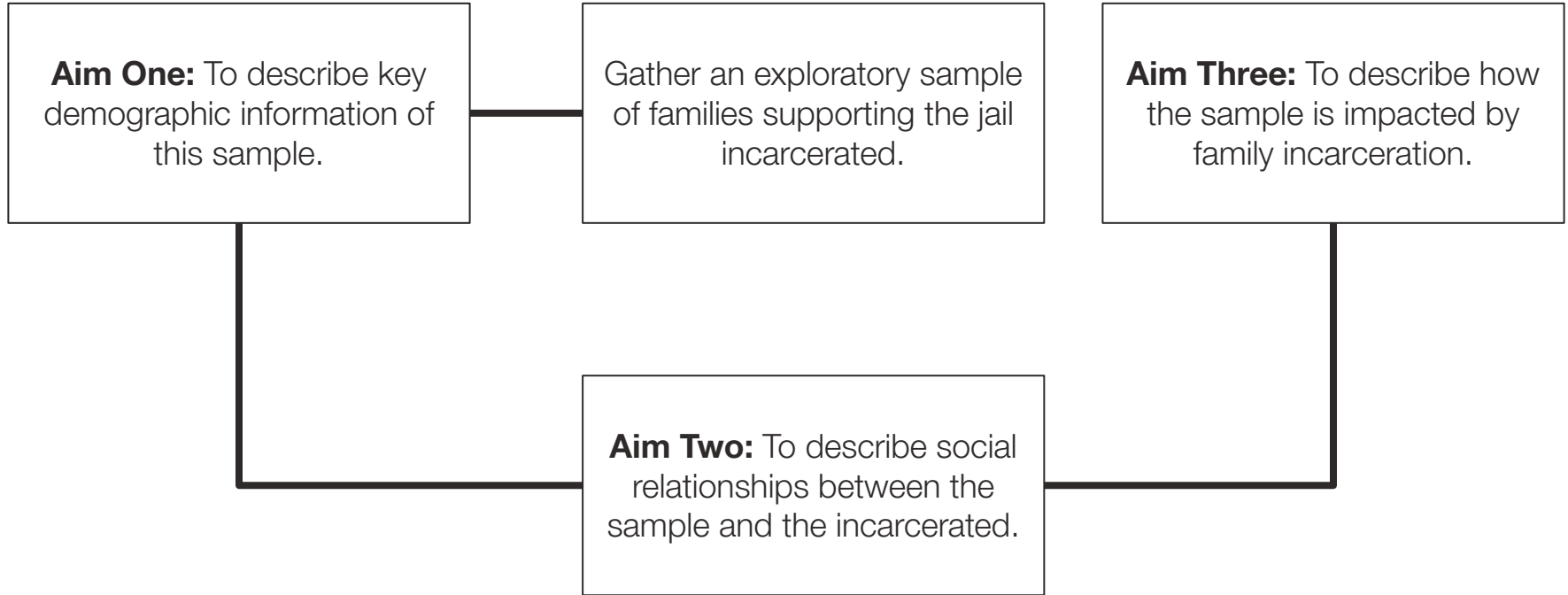
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Why are Families Important to Studying the Criminal Legal System?

- Today, incarceration is a common life event for the American family, with 45 percent of Americans nationally having experienced the incarceration of an immediate family member. (Enns et al. 2019)
- Research focuses largely on the effects of incarceration from the orientation of justice-involved individuals, while their families are described as the “hidden” or “invisible” victims of the criminal justice process. (Martin 2017)
- But, assessing the impacts of incarceration, and ultimately reducing incarceration to produce safer and more equitable communities like in Durham, depends on treating families as important stakeholders in our criminal legal systems.

Research Aims



Methodology

- 30 field hours spent collecting data at the Durham County Jail.
- Survey methodology with a paper questionnaire asking a mix of closed- and open-ended questions.
- Primarily surveyed respondents visiting the jail to support the incarcerated.
- Survey response rate was 64%.
- Final sample size was $n = 18$.

Results

Sample Demographic Characteristics

Jail incarceration in Durham implicates mostly marginalized mothers, who go beyond their means to confront its costs.

- Of the total sample:
 - 28 percent were men and 72 percent were women.
 - 78 percent were aged 35 or older (mean age was 48 years).
 - 33 percent had more than a high-school education.
 - 61 percent identified as Black; 22 percent identified as Latine.
 - 44 percent represented four-person or five-person households.
 - 39 percent reported incomes less than \$40,000; 61 percent reported incomes less than \$50,000.

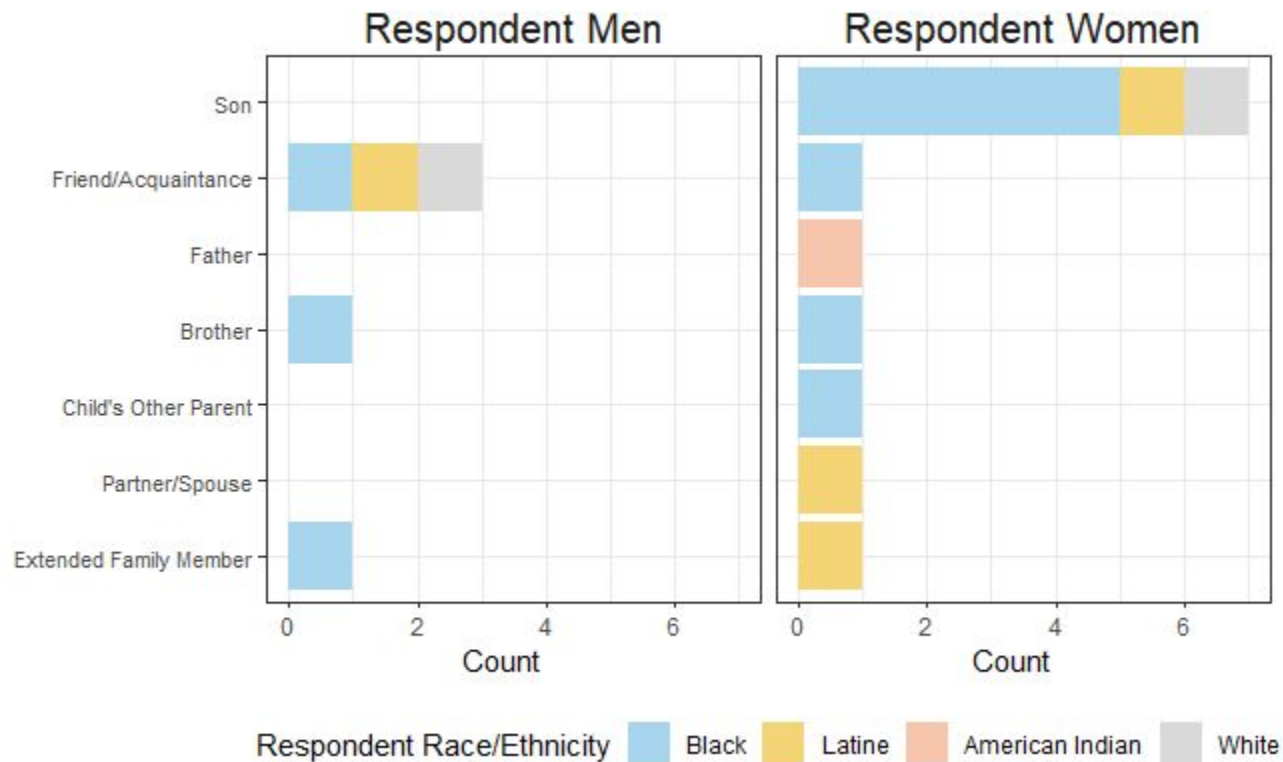


Figure 1. Describing family relationships between respondents and the incarcerated (n = 18).

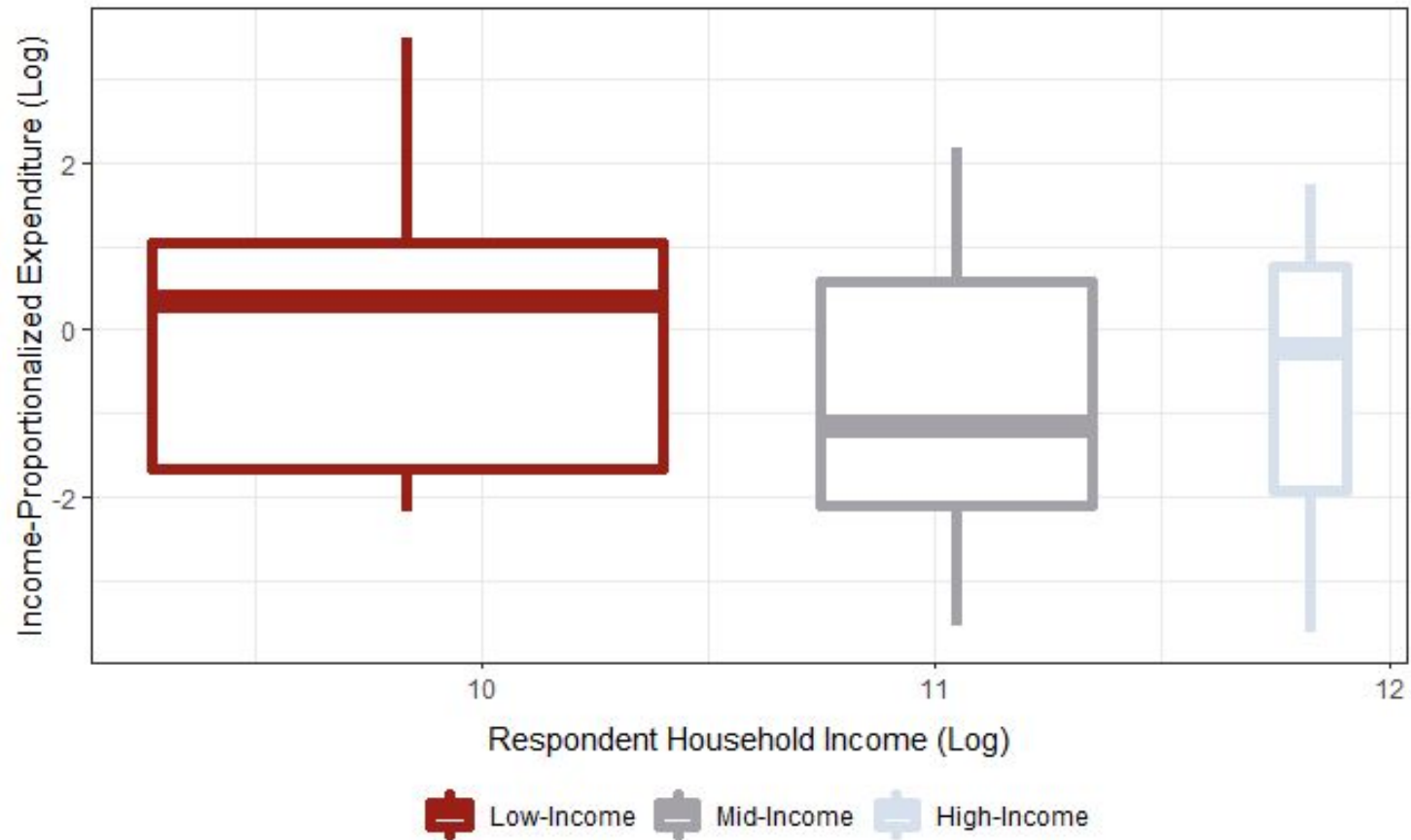


Figure 2. Comparing respondent income-proportionalized jail expenditure (n = 17).

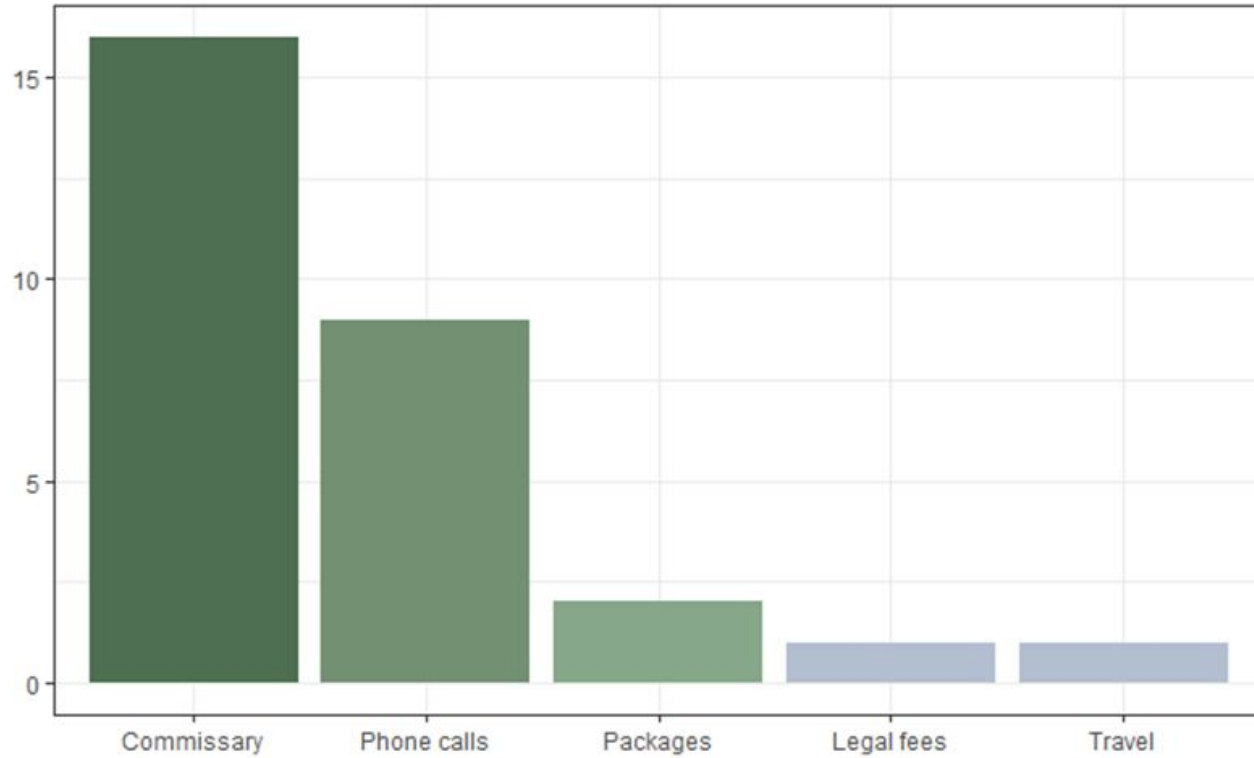
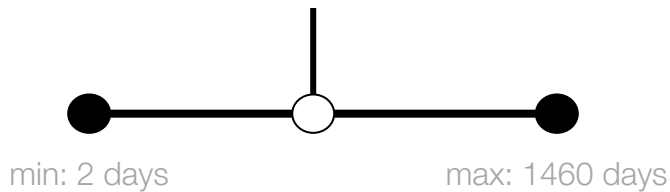


Figure 3. Most common sources of expense, categorized by frequency of survey mentions.

96 Days

median time spent by a family
member in jail



\$7200

highest amount spent by families
on support

\$11.39

average amount spent by families
per day

Qualitative Findings

The following selection of quoted responses were to the open-ended survey question: “Do you think the money you have spent directly on the individual in Durham County Detention Facility is an extra burden or challenge for you and/or your family?”

“Yes, sometimes when rent and bills are due on the same day, it is hard to deposit money to inmates.”

“Yes. They should not be charging us to put money inside the machine. He need[s] that for food.”

“It gets hard. I’m just a retiree, living on a fixed income. He’s my only child. Everything gets more and more expensive.”

Next Steps for Advancing Family Justice in Durham

- Continue to prioritize decarceration and other policies (e.g., bail or sentencing reform) that reduce or eliminate the time families spend apart.
- Actively involve justice-involved families in community outreach and take their concerns as legitimate; they often have an acute and honest awareness of the state of criminal justice.
- Demand accountability and transparency from our correctional institutions and law enforcement; cruel and unusual punishment, neglectful supervision, and inhumane treatment have no place in Durham or elsewhere.
- Fundamentally restructure or end private contracts in favor of providing subsidized or reduced-expense nutritional, hygienic, and communication needs and services.

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